

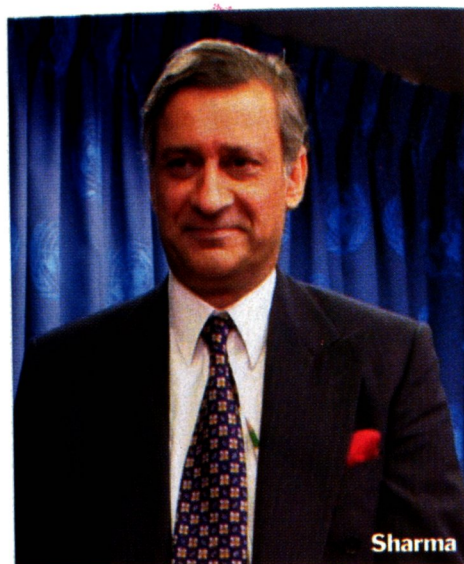
DELHI President General Pervez Musharraf's declaration of Emergency in Pakistan may cloud the forthcoming Commonwealth summit in Uganda but it is the battle for the post of the Commonwealth secretary-general which will be keenly watched here. India has to ensure that its candidate for the post—envoy to the UK Kamallesh Sharma—wins with a huge margin.

The 54-member body usually selects a secretary-general by consensus or by a straw poll behind closed doors. While the role of the Commonwealth has diminished over the last few years, for Delhi the election is an attempt to regain lost prestige after its candidate for the UN Security Council Shashi Tharoor lost the election last year. More recently, Finance Minister P. Chidambaram bowed out for the chair of the IMF's steering committee, where India lost the bid in

No Room for Global Goofups



Kaul



Sharma

the second round after some of its European and African supporters ditched it.

While from all estimates, the dice is loaded in favour of Sharma, an Indian spoiler, Mohan Kaul, who is the head of the Commonwealth Business Council, is also trying to cut into Indian

votes. Sharma has toured a majority of the 53 Commonwealth countries and has been assured an overwhelming support of 30 votes. Kaul, a PIO from the UK, may eat into his votes, which can help the third candidate, the foreign minister of Malta. "I will win if we have a secret voting. Many heads of

states have endorsed my candidature," said Kaul, who was in Delhi to meet Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. India now needs to ensure that there is no diplomatic slipup, for it will be a major blow to its aspirations of playing a key role in the global arena.

by Saurabh Shukla

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

A special AICC meeting is being called during the winter session of Parliament. Though the Gujarat elections and the nuclear deal form part of the agenda, the meeting will also felicitate the youngest AICC general secretary, Rahul Gandhi.

VOICES



"UPA talked to me on the nuclear deal but I said go to the politicians as talks between politicians are talks between equals."

Brajesh Mishra, former national security adviser

"The existing Gujarat Government had nothing to do with society, politics, humanity or principles. The crimes of 2002 and the truth make our heads hang in shame."

Sonia Gandhi, UPA chairperson

"I have decided to surrender to silence in the wake of electronic media unnecessarily targeting me and my party."

H.D. Kumaraswamy, former Karnataka chief minister and JD(S) leader

"A suicidal terrorist could reappear anywhere, anytime. There could be ad-hoc and isolated bomb blasts. This ought to be expected."

Mahinda Rajapakse, Sri Lankan President

"There is going to be no cut-down in my aggression. I'll be the same Sreesanth who gives his best every time he plays for the country."

S. Sreesanth, cricketer

